

the term with Beth-horon, a town on the border of Sam. (Jos. 16³. 5; cf. Montgomery, *Samaritans*,⁵⁸), of which place Sanb. might be a native and still governor of Sam. In what respect the appellative contained a note of contempt in Neh.'s time is not known.

The letter shows that the Jewish colonists in Elephantine looked upon the sons of Sanb. as friends who would be likely to assist their plea for the rebuilding of the temple in their garrison. This could not have been very long after Neh.'s second administration, and may seem to raise a doubt about the above identification. As a matter of fact, our sources show that, violently as Sanb. and others struggled against the rebuilding of the walls, and consequently against Neh. as the leader of that great work, there were friendly relations maintained by these foes with some prominent persons in Jerus. Jehohanan, the high priest in 407, or one of his brothers, had married a daughter of Sanb. (Ne. 13²⁸); correspondence was conducted between To. and the nobles of Judah (6¹⁷); and these were allied to him by marriage and agreements; Sanb. was able to hire a prophet to mislead the governor (6¹²). Neh.'s troubles were, in fact, greatly augmented by the disaffection of some of the leaders in Jerus. Again the Jewish colonists in Jeb show that they are not very well informed about affairs in the world outside, and they may have been ignorant of Sanb.'s intrigues against their fellow-Israelite. Finally, Sanb.'s sons, with their good Heb. names, may not have shared their father's hostility, esp. at a time when the wall had long been an accomplished fact.

To account for this hostility there is no need to go back to the repulse of the Sam.'s offer to aid in building the temple (Ezr. 4¹⁻²), still less to the later bitter feud between the Sam. and the Jews. As Montgomery has pointed out in his able work on the Sam. (⁵⁹), the opposition was political, not religious. In the time of Neh. the relations of the Sam. toward the Jews was exactly what the relations of the northern kingdom, the predecessors of the Sam., had always been to the kingdom of Judah. The exile, with the colonising and the return, had not materially altered the conditions. The Sam. and Jews could no more be one people than Ephraim and Judah could long be one state. As shown above, the rival people picked no quarrel with their southern neighbours as long as they were using their efforts to build up their ecclesiastical institutions. The temple would not interfere with the political supremacy of the north. But the building of the walls was another matter. Once let Jerus. be made impregnable again, as it had been in the days of old, and the balance of power would be almost certain to move from the north to the south. The Sam. would have been blind, indeed, had they not seen the significance of the movement, and foolish, indeed, if they had not used every possible means to prevent it.

Their first attempt succeeded. They frightened the weak Art. and

cowed the Jews who under some unknown inspiration and leadership had started the work. Their second attempt failed, and the cause of their failure was the presence of a personality against whom their utmost struggles were in vain.

§ 10. THE DATE OF EZRA'S MISSION.

It has been assumed in the preceding pages that Ezra belongs to a later period than Nehemiah. That conclusion seems to me inevitable. It is true that the editor of the books thought otherwise. His placing of *Ezr.* 7-10 before *Ne.* 1 shows that the Artaxerxes who authorised Ezra's administration was, in his view, the same as the Artaxerxes who appointed Nehemiah to be governor of Judah, and his placing of the promulgation of the law by Ezra (*Ne.* 8¹⁻¹²) in the midst of Nehemiah's rule shows his belief that they were contemporaries. Further to support his view, he has introduced Nehemiah in the story of the reading of the law (*Ne.* 8⁹). He also drags Ezra's name into the story of the dedication of the walls (*Ne.* 12³⁶), but it is a manifest gloss. In spite of the dissimilarity of their work, these two leaders could not be contemporaries.

For Art. would scarcely send two men to Judah at the same time, both clothed with similar powers. It would be strange, were Ezra such a prominent figure in Jerus., that there is no genuine reference to him in Neh.'s story. Neh. in his second administration was the first to discover mixed marriages and to apply a sharp remedy. Such a condition would not arise naturally after the wholesale dissolution as described in *Ezr.* 9 *f.* Neh.'s reforms, as narrated in c. 13, would be strange after Ezra, but are very natural before his time. It is inconceivable that the Lev. should be driven to work in the fields directly after Ezra's mission, or even possibly while it lasted. The measures Neh. took for the support of the temple show that his action could not have been preceded by the rule of a scribe-priest with ample authority to enforce the law. Moreover, the Jerus. of Neh.'s time was a desolation, without walls or houses or people (7⁴). Ezra's whole career is spent in the holy city, and there appears to have been plenty of houses and people in his time.

There is the evidence of *Esd.* which connects *Ne.* 7¹²-8¹³ directly with *Ezr.* 10, thus bringing the Ezra story together. There is nothing about Neh.'s work in this the earliest edition of our books. *Jos.* has a section dealing with Neh.'s administration (*Ant.* xi, 5, 6-8). Before

he takes up the story of Neh. he describes the death of Ezra at an advanced age (*ib.* § 5). Jos. follows Esd. as his authority, so that the testimony is emphatic on this negative point—that Ezra and Neh. were not contemporaries. Further Jos. says that both Ezra and Neh. flourished in the reign of Xerxes (485–464), and he relates that the death of Joakim the high pr. took place at about the same time as that of Ezra. Now Joakim was the son of Jes. (Ne. 12¹⁰), and he might have ruled in the time of Xerxes, but he could hardly survive till the reign of Art. As Jos. followed his sources pretty closely, it is perfectly possible that the date of Ezra in the original text of Esd. was the reign of Xerxes, and that Art. is one of the many modifications in that text based on MT. As the version of Esd. lost favour largely owing to Jer.'s great influence (*cf.* ES.¹³), there was an evident effort to recover its lost prestige by eliminating its variations from MT. Such a date for Ezra is not impossible, esp. when the scope of his mission is properly limited. He must be separated from Neh. by a considerable space of time.

Such evidence as we have in our sources, however, points to the conclusion that Ezra followed Neh. To that evidence we now turn.

In Ezra's prayer he refers to God's grace as manifested before his time, and among other evidences cites "the giving of a wall [in Judah and] in Jerus." (Ezr. 9⁸). As shown in the notes, the reference can only be to the wall built by Neh. We are told that Ezra went into the chamber of Jehohanan the son of Eliashib to spend the night (Ezr. 10⁶). The succession of high pr. in Ne. 12²² shows that Jehohanan is identical with Jonathan (12¹¹) and that he was the grandson of Eliashib (so *Sta. Gesch.* ii.¹⁵³). Now as Eliashib was a contemporary of Neh., Ezra is two generations later, or exactly where he belongs, in the reign of Art. II. Neh.'s administration began in 444, and Ezra's in 397 or later. Finally in Ne. 12²⁸ we have the order "Neh. the governor and Ezra the pr., the scribe," and these are not contemporaries, but belong to successive periods. It does not help, therefore, to correct the text of Ezr. 7¹, as proposed by We. (*Gesch.*^{169,n}), reading 27th instead of 7th. Indeed, that would make matters worse, for as Neh. was governor of Judah from the 20th to the 32d years of Art., we should then have Ezra coming up in the very midst of Neh.'s rule. It is certainly simpler to suppose that the reference is to Art. II.

These considerations fix the date of Neh. as that of the reign of Art. I (Longimanus), 464–424. Torrey insists that "the tradition represented by the Aram. document and the Chr." places Neh.'s work in the reign of Art. II (Mnemon), 404–358 B.C., and says that we have no means of determining which Art. was the benefactor of Neh. (*Comp.*⁶⁵, ES.³³⁶). This conclusion comes from taking Chr.'s arrangement too seriously. Ezra could hardly have been later than Art. II, and I have shown that he followed Neh. Moreover, Neh. must have

been familiar with Pers. history. He could hardly have held high place at the court without knowing the succession of the Pers. kings. If his benefactor had been preceded shortly before by a king of the same name, he would in all probability have taken pains to specify the later Art., as Jos. does, τοῦ ἄλλου Αρταξέργου (*Ant. Ed. Niese*, iii,^{60 f.}, quoted by Sachau,⁷).

This date has received strong confirmation from the Eleph. pap. Jehohanan was high pr. at Jerus. in 407 B.C. As he was the grandson of Eliashib, a contemporary of Neh. (*v. s.*), Neh. must have preceded this time. This argument has been elaborated by Sachau (*l. c.*). Another notice from the same letter supports the conclusion. Sanb.'s sons were prominent men in Sam. at the date given above, 407 B.C. As this person is to be identified with Neh.'s persistent foe, Sanb., if still living, must have been a fairly old man, so that his prime of life would exactly coincide with the date of Neh. Arnold has added confirmation of this date from the presence of a Hananijah, as a high Pers. official in Egypt, and who was probably the same as Hanani, the brother of Neh. (*JBL*. 1912,³⁰).

Taking all the evidence there is no longer room for the slightest doubt that the protector of Neh. was Art. Longimanus. In his later work Torrey now admits the probability of this date, but he will go no further (*ES*.^{140. 228. 335}).

§ II. THE HISTORY OF THE PERSIAN PERIOD.

Outside of some prophetic passages and Psalms, which cannot always be positively dated, our books contain all the information we have about the historical events of the important Persian period, 538-332 B.C., and so slightly more than two centuries. If every word of Ezr.-Ne. were authentic, our knowledge would be meagre, for we have practically nothing until we reach the reign of Darius I, 521-485, and but a brief note, which yields little information, from the reign of the famous Xerxes, 485-464. From the completion of the temple, about 515 B.C., until the advent of Nehemiah, 444 B.C., there is a long period, nearly three-quarters of a century, about the history of which we have but slight knowledge.

A characteristic of our books is that they give us information about a very few specific events, each of which occupies but a short time, and then a great gap is left. Thus Ezr. 3-6 (exc. 4⁴⁻²⁴) contains the story of the rebuilding of the temple, Ne. 1-6 the story of the building of the